

A remade Kennedy Center, 10 months in

After creating a showier and more political venue, Trump to host its honors

BY TRAVIS M. ANDREWS AND JANAY KINGSBERRY

On the day in February that President Donald Trump took over the John F. Kennedy Center for the Performing Arts, his new board ousted Deborah Rutter, the longtime president of the institution. She gathered her staff to offer a hopeful farewell. That evening, she welcomed other leaders to her home to mourn.

“As with any wake, you drink a little too much, and you tell stories, and you laugh, and you cry,” Rutter told The Washington Post in a conversation in the spring.

Rutter had planned to step down at the end of 2025 after leading the Kennedy Center through a decade in which it had diversified its offerings, endured the 2020 lockdown and emerged to boast robust ticket sales and, according to publicly available tax filings, steadily grown revenue.

She still had four major items on her to-do list: growing the center’s endowment; furthering its work as an arts educator around the country; strengthening the financials of the National Symphony Orchestra; and renewing the contract with CBS or finding a new broadcast partner to air the Kennedy Center Honors.

Those plans died. But the Kennedy Center did not.

SEE KENNEDY CENTER ON A12

What to know: Tonight’s Honors will cap a tumultuous year. **A13**



JOE RAEDLE/GETTY IMAGES

A gas station customer fills up in Miami. President Donald Trump predicts prices, just below \$3 a gallon nationally, will fall to \$2.

Trump’s affordability pitch falters

President veers between insisting that he’s cutting prices and dismissing the issue as a fraud

BY NAFTALI BENDAVID

President Donald Trump has said drug prices are falling by as much as 1,500 percent, a mathematical impossibility. He has declared himself “the affordability president,” while dismissing the affordability issue as “a con job by the Democrats.”

Trump also vows that good times are coming. He has predicted that gas prices, which now hover around \$3 a gallon,

will plummet to \$2. He has promised Americans \$2,000 refund checks from the revenue raised by tariffs. He has suggested that “in the not-too-distant future,” no one will have to pay income tax.

This flurry of sometimes extravagant claims comes amid a growing Republican fear, fueled by recent election results, that high prices could set the stage for a Democratic sweep in next year’s midterms. So far, there is

little evidence that Trump’s urgent attempt to shift the economic storyline is working.

“Any Republican who refuses to admit we have an affordability problem is not listening to the American people,” former House speaker Newt Gingrich (R-Georgia) said. “It’s real because the American people think it’s real. I cannot overstate that — in a free country — it’s the people who define what is real, not the politicians.”

Gingrich said Republicans need to quickly adopt an “affordability agenda” and argued that Trump should dedicate his next State of the Union address to the subject. “Psychologically, he hates to admit being in a hole,” Gingrich said. “His whole career is built around forcing the positive.”

Trump’s plight is a striking turnaround. In last year’s campaign, Trump scored political

SEE AFFORDABILITY ON A8

Adoptions rise as ‘dog in the backpack’ goes viral

BY SYDNEY PAGE

On a recent afternoon in a New York City subway car, a white dog with brown spots peered out of a man’s backpack. The dog, named Bertha, gave him constant licks.

Bertha was found on the streets in October, and was taken in by Animal Care Centers of NYC. Although she had a rough start in life, on this day, she seemed overjoyed. She welcomed neck scratches from dozens of strangers, picked out a new toy, devoured a pup cup and enjoyed a long walk. The outing led to her adoption a few days later.

The man carrying her was not her owner, but a volunteer of sorts. Bryan Reisberg spends one day a week taking shelter dogs like Bertha out of their kennels, lifting them into a backpack that says “adopt me” and bringing them onto the subway and around New York. His goal is for people to see shelter dogs as he does: curious, sweet and a potential pet.

“The personality on this little girl, I truly did not want to leave her,” Reisberg said of Bertha. “She was just trying to kiss and love on people.”

Reisberg has a professional background in film. He shoots videos of each of the dogs he takes out for the day and shares a polished compilation on social media. Across various social platforms, the videos have more than

SEE DOGS ON A10



ERIN PATRICK O’CONNOR/THE WASHINGTON POST

The Washington Post followed 11-year-old Lozen Brown-Lopez through her Sunrise Dance ceremony.

Sun may be setting on sacred ritual

An Apache girl’s ceremony could be the last as copper mining threatens

BY DANA HEDGPETH, ERIN PATRICK O’CONNOR AND TIM MEKO

The girl danced in the knee-deep water as slanting rain pelted down. She had been dancing like this for hours, her slight frame weighed down by a sodden buckskin dress. Each step brought her closer to the end of a ritual that also signified a beginning. ¶ Several days earlier, Lozen Brown-Lopez had arrived at the top of Oak Flat, a red-rocked mountain in southern Arizona. She was 12 years old, from the San Carlos Apache Tribe and about to endure a grueling four-day ceremony known as the Sunrise Dance that has been practiced by Apaches for centuries. Surrounded by a hundred family and fellow tribal members, dancers, singers and medicine men, she would reenact their creation story. And at the end of the ceremony, after she had been daubed in clay to represent the mythical mother of all Apaches and ritually cleansed, Lozen would emerge as a young woman.

SEE OAK FLAT ON A18

Vacancies beset weather offices as winter arrives

Over half a dozen states see shortage despite vow to rehire after DOGE cuts

BY RUBY MELLEN AND HANNAH NATANSON

As snow blankets a broadening swath of the United States and meteorological winter sets in, the National Weather Service remains constrained by a severe staffing shortage, despite a Trump administration commitment to refill hundreds of jobs cut by Elon Musk’s U.S. DOGE Service.

The administration gave the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration, which oversees the Weather Service, permission to post 450 critical roles — seeming to acknowledge that DOGE had gone too far in a push for cuts that resulted in some 550 firings, resignations and early retirements. Back in June, National Weather Service Director Ken Graham called the ability to rehire “fantastic news” that would enable “timely and accurate forecasts and warnings.”

But months later, offices in more than half a dozen states, from Maine to Wyoming, have vacancies, according to Tom Fahy, the legislative director for the National Weather Service Employees Organization (NWSEO), citing the latest figures tracked by the group. The unfilled roles include meteorologists, technical experts and sci-

entists who work to deliver accurate forecasts and warnings to communities around-the-clock.

In some locations, nearly half of the meteorologist roles were left vacant.

NOAA said progress in hiring has been made. “The NWS successfully advertised 184 positions to date, and the final selections and onboarding of employees are in various stages,” NOAA spokeswoman Kim Doster told The Washington Post in a statement Friday. She added that the Weather Service was on track to fill the remaining authorized roles by the end of the 2026 fiscal year.

But many of these specialized and demanding jobs have historically taken up to a year to hire for, said Rick Spinrad, who served as the agency’s administrator under President Joe Biden.

Any shortages could put communities at risk, weather experts said.

“It would not be a surprise if we saw a major devastating storm this winter, for which loss of life and damage to property in part was a consequence of not being as prepared as we were with a fully staffed NOAA,” said Spinrad.

The NWSEO’s latest vacancy figures are as of Oct. 1, Fahy said. Federal hiring stalled during the 43-day government shutdown.

The shortages are widespread across some of the coldest, snowiest parts of the country.

The office in Des Moines has eight meteorologists on staff, but Fahy said that, according to the latest count, it was short six

SEE WEATHER SERVICE ON A9

SPORTS

Baba Oladotun dreams of the NBA, and that leaves little time to be a kid.

THE WORLD

With a vote following the deadly fire, Hong Kong targets dissent. **A14**



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